

Chapter 59: 晚了 (Too Late)

Let alone Ning Fuyi's trio, even the palace servant who had made the recommendation was stunned. However, having stayed in the palace for so long, that person was extremely tactful. She immediately suppressed her reaction and excitedly waved toward the back: "Didn't you hear what His Majesty said? Quickly take her to be cleaned and dressed!"

As soon as she finished speaking, several strong palace servants rushed out from the side. Some grabbed hands, others grabbed feet, and they directly lifted Qiu Yi up. Unable to struggle, Qiu Yi was so frightened her face changed color as her body was carried along with their force toward the inner palace.

Chu Qingqiu moved slightly but was held back by Ning Fuyi pulling her sleeve from behind.

"Master, what should I do?" Qiu Yi's panicked voice came through their minds.

"Don't be afraid first. Look for opportunities to judge whether she's a demon. If she really wants to do something to you, use divine consciousness to tell us—I have ways to rescue you." Chu Qingqiu said.

After they finished these two sentences, Qiu Yi's figure had already disappeared among the layered palace walls. The elderly palace servant breathed a sigh of relief and said respectfully: "Your Majesty, for the rest of these, should we drive them out of the palace, or..."

"Keep a few to serve in the bedchamber. Drive out the rest." After the female emperor spoke, she didn't spare even a glance for the remaining people. Her long sleeves fluttered slightly as she strode away.

The surrounding palace servants immediately lowered their heads and followed, forming a long, impressive procession.

The elderly palace servant swept her gaze over the remaining people and finally casually pointed to three or four at the end of the formation: "You will come with me to serve in the bedchamber later. The rest, leave."

By coincidence, among those she kept were Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu. They didn't need to waste words and quietly stood to the side, watching the others leave.

"You all, come with me." The elderly palace servant said, turning toward the direction of the bedchamber.

The female emperor's bedchamber was at the very center of the inner palace courtyard. Along the way, they passed through many gardens with beautiful scenery. Ning Fuyi secretly memorized the route. After walking for about the time of one incense stick, the sleeping hall finally appeared among the palace walls.

"Yingxia¹, these are new palace servants. Take them to change clothes, search them thoroughly, and question their family backgrounds. If there are no problems, they can start working." The elderly palace servant handed the several people over to a young woman and then turned to leave.

The woman called Yingxia spoke much more gently. She said "follow me" and led them across the threshold into the dim corridor.

At first it was quite quiet, but after a while, one of the accompanying women couldn't hold back and carefully asked: "Sister, why are there so few palace servants in His Majesty's bedchamber?"

Hearing this, Yingxia looked left and right, then said: "There used to be many palace servants, but recently people keep offending His Majesty. They've all been beaten with boards and driven out of the inner courtyard, or driven out of the palace entirely. You should all be careful with your words and actions in daily life, lest you anger His Majesty."

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi looked toward Chu Qingqiu and saw that she was also looking at her, knowing they were thinking the same thing. This female emperor definitely had something fishy about her—that's why she drove everyone out of the palace to prevent being discovered. She was most likely an impostor who had seized the original female emperor's position. It was just unknown where the original female emperor was hidden, or whether she was already dead.

"Qiu Yi, how are things on your end?" Ning Fuyi asked in her mind.

After a long while, Qiu Yi's trembling voice finally came through: "No problems for now. I'm in the sleeping hall, and the female emperor hasn't come yet."

Yingxia gave the palace servants clothing to change into, only searched their bodies for weapons, and didn't question them much before assigning them to work. It was clear the palace was indeed urgently short-handed.

Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu were assigned to clean the imperial study. By this time, the sky had completely darkened. In the inner palace courtyard, only a few pavilions and halls had lamplight—the rest were pitch-black and deathly silent.

Ning Fuyi pushed open the great doors of the imperial study with a creak, immediately met by the scent of books and pine fragrance. However, it wasn't pleasant—instead, it was so strong it was choking.

Ning Fuyi waved forcefully at her nose, then followed her instincts inside. In the pitch-black darkness where she couldn't see her hand in front of her face, she groped around for a long time before finally touching a candlestick and lighting it.

The dim firelight illuminated the hall interior. As soon as Ning Fuyi's eyes adjusted to the light, her gaze suddenly collided with a bizarre human face, making her heart feel like it had been punched—thump thump thump it started racing.

Chu Qingqiu, following behind her, was obviously also startled but didn't make a sound.

"This female emperor is truly terrifying. Why hang such a portrait instead of nice landscapes in a perfectly good study?" Ning Fuyi couldn't help but speak as she turned to light the remaining candles. Only when all the shadows were replaced by firelight did she stop.

Chu Qingqiu exhaled and turned back to close the door, then carefully examined the portrait.

The person in the portrait had fierce, menacing features like an evil spirit, yet held a golden pagoda in their hands, with auspicious clouds depicted in dark ink at the pagoda's tip.

"Chi Du²." Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke.

Ning Fuyi, who was studying the books piled like a small mountain nearby, turned back upon hearing this: "What?"

"This person is named Chi Du, an ancient god who, due to his ugly and fierce appearance, was not revered by the world." Chu Qingqiu answered, also falling into confusion. "According to common sense, no one would worship a portrait of Chi Du."

Ning Fuyi put down the stack of documents in her hands and quickly walked to Chu Qingqiu's side.

She had read some history books in the library a few days ago. Although there were many ancient gods, only a few were famous: Tang Huang, Hong Xi, Chi Du, and Ting Feng were the most powerful god races at that time, each occupying one quarter of the world.

Ting Feng was the Ting Feng Goddess they had seen at Zhaoyao Mountain. The other gods had long been buried in the years—even cultivators hardly remembered them, let alone mortals.

Just then, Qiu Yi's voice suddenly came through their minds: "Master, where are you?"

"In the study. We've discovered some things." Chu Qingqiu answered, extending her five fingers to gently brush over the portrait. When her fingertips moved to the pagoda Chi Du held in his hands, her expression changed slightly.

Standing quite far away, Ning Fuyi also sharply noticed that the pagoda seemed to move slightly following Chu Qingqiu's finger.

"This disciple has circled around the sleeping hall but found nothing unusual." Qiu Yi replied, her tone no longer as fearful.

She had already been alone in the sleeping hall for an hour. During this hour, she hadn't seen even half a person's shadow. Even the palace servants at the door had disappeared, but before leaving, they had locked the main gate, sealing off her escape route.

This sleeping hall was much the same as all royal chambers—with four screens creating separated areas inside and outside that had to be passed through one by one to reach where the female emperor rested. The bed was carved in the shape of a dragon, with the dragon's head inlaid with gold and a jade stone held in its mouth.

Qiu Yi had scattered all the rolled-up bedding on the bed but hadn't found anything unusual.

Suddenly, footsteps came from outside the door. Qiu Yi immediately sat back on the bed like a startled animal, her fingers gripping the edge of the bed tightly as she looked up and listened carefully to the sounds.

The door opened. The sound of robes dragging on the ground came rustling.

No palace servants followed her—only the female emperor entered alone. Her footsteps were light and rhythmic. On the thirty-second count, she rounded the wide screen and appeared before Qiu Yi.

Qiu Yi's body leaned back slightly, staring intently at the woman before her.

She had only felt amazed when outside the door earlier, but now with the dim lamplight reflecting in the woman's eyes, her innate charm completely took over.

"Many people have come to my chambers, but I've never seen one so bold as to stare at me without looking away." The woman suddenly smiled, her red lips as vivid as blood. She suddenly stretched her hands to both sides, gesturing for Qiu Yi to come forward.

Having grown up by Chu Qingqiu's side since childhood, Qiu Yi had never encountered such a scene and just stayed in place without moving.

"Tsk." The woman shook her head lightly. "Still one without any sense."

However, she didn't make things difficult for Qiu Yi but instead reached out to undo her outer robe herself, casually tossing it onto the screen.

After removing the wide outer robe, she wore only a bright red gauze dress underneath, its hem spreading like blazing fire. She reached out to touch Qiu Yi's face, but Qiu Yi suddenly screamed and sprang up as if her bottom was on fire, retreating repeatedly and nearly knocking over the screen with the outer robe hanging on it.

"What's wrong?" Perhaps her scream was accompanied by uncontrolled thoughts that Chu Qingqiu and Ning Fuyi heard, because Ning Fuyi's voice came through their minds.

"The female emperor has come." Qiu Yi's face was completely red as she warily watched the composed woman, speaking in her mind.

"What did she do?" Ning Fuyi asked again.

"She..." Qiu Yi gripped the screen, her voice trembling. "She took off her clothes."

Silence filled their minds before Chu Qingqiu's voice came through: "Wait a moment. Your master will come quickly."

"No!" Qiu Yi quickly spoke aloud. "She hasn't done anything yet. This disciple can hold on a bit longer. Master, didn't you just discover something? Do you have any leads?"

"Almost there."

"Then Master needn't worry about me first," Qiu Yi said nervously in her mind.

"We'll discuss after investigating the truth."

An "mm" sound came through their minds, then silence. Only then did Qiu Yi's attention return to the scene before her. The woman was using her rouge-painted fingertips to support her temples, smiling as she looked over at her.

It should have been an extremely beautiful scene, but it gave her goosebumps all over.

"Why are you so afraid of me?" the woman said softly, her voice soft and deep like a flute playing from afar.

Qiu Yi didn't speak, but her body involuntarily stepped backward. The woman twisted her waist and stood up, walking toward her step by step. Qiu Yi hurriedly tried to run, but though the woman's movements looked slow, she couldn't escape at all. She had only run two steps when her hands were firmly bound behind her back.

Then cold rope wound around twice, actually binding her tightly.

"What are you doing! Let go!" Qiu Yi said angrily, but the woman had surprisingly great strength. With just a light lift and pull, her body was turned completely upside down and she fell backward onto the bed.

Looking up again, the woman's high nose was close at hand. The strange fragrance from her body made Qiu Yi's eyes nearly tear up. She desperately turned her head to one side, involuntarily cursing.

"Such a small girl, yet your curses are so unpleasant." The woman suddenly reached out to grab her chin, forcing her to face forward, then brought her red lips close to her ear.

She said softly: "Is this how your master taught you?"

Qiu Yi, who had been struggling desperately just moments before, suddenly froze. Fear soaked through her limbs like cold water, and she immediately began shouting in her mind: "Master! Master! Run quickly..."

Her ears were quiet for a long while before Chu Qingqiu's calm voice finally responded.

"Too late," she said.

Footnotes:

1. 迎夏 (Yingxia) - A palace servant's name meaning "Welcoming Summer."
2. 赤都 (Chi Du) - An ancient god mentioned in the story, whose name literally means "Red Capital" or "Crimson Capital."